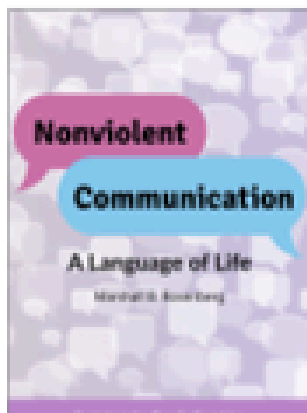




NONVIOLENT COMMUNICATION

A Language of Life

Marshall B. Rosenberg



The Big “So What”

This book is a detailed guide for Nonviolent Communication (NVC)—an empathic way of thinking and communicating that leads to connection, mutual understanding, and solutions that can fully satisfy *all* parties’ needs. This approach can be applied to all types of situations, from intimate relationships to organizational and diplomatic relations.



Introduction: What is Nonviolent Communication?



Nonviolent Communication (NVC) was developed by psychologist Marshall Rosenberg. It trains us to carefully observe and identify the behaviors/conditions that affect us, express ourselves effectively, and listen deeply to foster respect and understanding.

- NVC is both a process and a mindset. It’s a way to see other people in a compassionate way even under trying circumstances, to listen and speak from the heart, and connect deeply with ourselves and with one another.
- It is not meant to be applied rigidly like a fixed formula, but to be adapted flexibly to suit different types of situations, relationships, and conflicts. This book captures the concepts, principles and approaches for NVC.



Communicating with Compassion



When we interact with others, we may unknowingly read into their messages, defend ourselves, or attack what they say. We think we’ve expressed ourselves clearly, when we may not

KEY QUOTES

“NVC helps us connect with each other and ourselves in a way that allows our natural compassion to flourish.”

“The essence of NVC is in our consciousness...not in the actual words that are exchanged.”

“NVC is not a set formula, but something that adapts to various situations as well as personal and cultural styles.”

“Life-alienating communication...traps us in a world of ideas about rightness and wrongness—a world of judgments.”

even know what we truly want or need. Rosenberg identifies several types of communication that alienate people and block compassion:

- When others don't act in alignment with our values, we make moralistic judgments that imply they are bad or wrong. We use labels like "lazy," "selfish," or "racist," to judge or classify people, blocking empathy and understanding.
- We make comparisons between people to create feelings of superiority or inferiority. These hinder empathy or appreciation for others' unique traits and circumstances.
- We deny personal responsibility and blame our thoughts, feelings, or actions on other people, external circumstances, social norms, rules or policies. We say things like "I have to..." "They made me..." or "The boss said so..."
- We express our desires as demands, making explicit/implicit threats to punish others if they don't do what we want. We seek to change other people, and push them to do what we want (regardless of what they want). When they don't act the way we expect or approve of, we believe that they deserve to be punished. In turn, others feel resentful or resistant for being coerced.

 By contrast, NVC uses 4 key components to communicate clearly and empathically, without blame or criticism:

- Observations: Observe the concrete actions that affect us.
- Feelings: Identify and express how we feel in relation to those observations.
- Needs: Identify the needs, wants, and values that create those feelings.
- Requests: Make specific requests that fulfill our needs and enrich our lives.

For example, instead of making sarcastic remarks or demanding that your partner puts away his phone during dinner, you might say: "When I notice that you are on your phone during dinner time (*observation*), I feel neglected (*feeling*) because I need connection and presence during our shared moments (*need*). Would you be willing to put your phone away when we eat (*request*)?"

"We all pay dearly when people respond to our values and needs not out of a desire to give from the heart, but out of fear, guilt, or shame."

 In the next sections, we'll elaborate on how to use the 4 components in 2 parts to:

- Honestly express our needs and feelings; and
- Empathically receive others' needs and feelings.



Expressing Yourself Honestly

Use the 4 components of NVC to (i) *observe* a situation, (ii) articulate how you *feel*, (iii) express what you *need*, and (iv) make a specific *request*.

1. Observe Without Evaluation

 Separate observations from evaluations. Describe only what you can see or hear, i.e. things that can be captured in a video. Exclude your interpretations, analyses, or judgments.

- When we mix up observations and evaluations, it sounds like a criticism to the receiving party, which leads to resistance. You can still have your own opinions or evaluations. However, make a conscious effort to separate your opinions from your observations. For example:

Language	Observation mixed with evaluation	Observation separated from evaluation
Use "to be" verbs instead of specifying your perspectives.	You are selfish.	When I see you take the last slice of pizza without asking if anyone else wants it, I think you're being selfish.

KEY QUOTES

"When we combine observation with evaluation, people are apt to hear criticism."

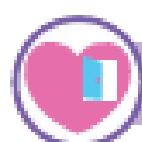
Language	Observation mixed with evaluation	Observation separated from evaluation
Use verbs with built-in judgments	Sarah gossips.	I heard Sarah sharing personal info about other colleagues 3x today.
Stating someone's thoughts, feelings, or intentions as fact.	He doesn't care about this project.	He hasn't participated in our last 3 project meetings, which gives me the impression that he may not care about this project.
Assume your prediction is a certainty.	If you keep staying up late, you will fail your exams.	If you keep staying up late, I worry that you may struggle in your exams.
Being vague about who/what you're referring to.	Teenagers are such reckless drivers.	My teenage nephew received 3 speeding tickets this month.
Describe an ability as if it's a fact.	Clara is a lousy writer.	Clara failed her last 3 writing assignments.
Use adjectives or adverbs rather than specify your opinion.	This soup is terrible.	The taste of this soup isn't appealing to me.
Being vague about frequency.	You seldom listen.	In our last 5 discussions, you changed the subject or used your phone while I was still speaking.
Generalizing or exaggerating	He's always late.	For our last 4 meetings, he arrived 15min after the agreed time.

KEY QUOTES

"For most of us, it is difficult to make observations, especially of people and their behavior, that are free of judgment, criticism, or other forms of analysis."

"Our repertoire of words for calling people names is often larger than our vocabulary of words to clearly describe our emotional states."

"Distinguish between what we feel and what we think we are."



2. Identify and Express How You Feel

 This is about identifying and expressing how you feel due to the observations. However, most of us are so used to suppressing or ignoring our feelings that we find it hard to express them.

- We confuse our feelings with our thoughts or opinions. These can usually be identified when the words "I feel..." are followed by the words "that," "like," "as if," or a name, noun, or pronoun (e.g. "I," "you," or "they"). For example:

Expressing Non-Feelings	Expressing Feelings
"I feel like I'm talking to a wall."	"I feel uncertain when you don't respond to what I say."
"I feel Tim is being unfair."	"I feel upset when I perceive Tim to allocate tasks unequally between team members."
"I feel this is pointless."	"I feel frustrated because I need to see some progress in our discussion."

- We also confuse our feelings with our sense of identity, and our interpretation of how others see/treat us. For example:

KEY QUOTES

- Interpersonal connection: Love, trust, and acceptance.
- Spiritual well-being: Experiencing beauty, harmony, peace, and inspiration.
- Physical well-being: Meeting basic needs like food, shelter, or rest.
- Play: Enjoying fun and laughter.



Take emotional responsibility. According to Rosenberg, your feelings come from your own needs, expectations, and perceptions. Others' words and actions might trigger feelings in you, but they cannot *cause* those feelings.

- Your create your own feelings. Imagine you're stuck in traffic and someone cuts into your lane.
 - If you're late for an appointment, you might get angry and start shouting "What an idiot! Do you think you're the only one in a rush?"
 - If you're ahead of schedule, you might be happy for the slow commute to enjoy your audiobook.
- You can choose your responses. Imagine your partner says, "You didn't take out the trash again!" You can respond in 4 ways.
 - Blame yourself*: "I'm so forgetful. I can't get anything right."
 - Blame others*: "Well, I forgot because you didn't remind me!"
 - Perceive your own feelings and needs without blame*: "I see that I forgot the trash again. I feel frustrated because I need to remember my tasks better. Could we brainstorm ways to help me remember this task in the future?"
 - Perceive others' feelings and needs, even if they're not explicitly expressed*: "It sounds like you're feeling frustrated because you need more help with the household chores. Is that right?"

The first 2 responses block compassion to create shame, guilt, resentment, or defensiveness. The last 2 responses connect feelings to needs, making it easier to respond compassionately.

"What others say and do may be the stimulus, but never the cause, of our feelings."

*"People are disturbed not by things, but by the view they take of them."
—Epictetus*

"Our feelings result from how we choose to receive what others say and do, as well as from our particular needs and expectations in that moment."



Take emotional responsibility by connecting feelings to needs.

- Do not use speech patterns that deny or mask emotional accountability. These include:
 - (i) Using *impersonal pronouns* like “it” or “that”, e.g. “It’s really infuriating” or “That really bugs me.”
 - (ii) Attributing your feelings to *someone’s actions*, e.g. “I feel hurt because you broke your promise” or “You make me feel...”
- Do use the words “I feel...because I...” For example, “I feel hurt that you broke your promise because I value reliability and trust.”



You’re likely to move through 3 stages as you develop emotional responsibility:

- “Emotional slavery”: Initially, you take too much responsibility for others’ feelings. To keep everyone happy, you suppress your own needs, only to feel tired and resentful.
- As you realize that you’re not responsible for others’ feelings, you might swing to the other extreme—to assert your own needs aggressively and ignore others’ needs with comments like “That’s not my problem” or “I’m not your servant.” Rosenberg calls this the “obnoxious stage.”
- You achieve “emotional liberation” when you balance between emotional responsibility and empathy. You own and communicate your feelings and needs, while concurrently empathizing with others’ feelings and needs. You might say something like: “I understand that you need my help, and I’d love to be there for you. I’m just feeling overwhelmed with my workload right now. Can we find another way or time to address your needs?”



4. Make Requests to Meet Your Needs



After expressing your observations, feelings and needs, you can now convey clear, specific requests that would satisfy your needs and enrich your life.

KEY QUOTES

“It can be difficult to make clear requests. But think how hard it will be for others to respond to our request if we’re not even clear what it is!”

KEY QUOTES

"How do we express our requests so that others are more willing to respond compassionately to our needs?"

- Use positive language to ask for what you want, rather than what you don't want. Make sure your request is specific, achievable, and can satisfy the needs you identified. Use the phrase "Would you be willing to...?"
- You need all 4 components for NVC to work. If you express your feelings without an actionable request, the other person won't know what you want from them. If you make a request without expressing your feelings, it could come across like a demand.
- Even if you articulate your request clearly, the other person may not hear the intended message. To verify that the message has been accurately heard and understood, ask the listener to paraphrase or reflect back what you said.
 - (i) Express appreciation if they try to reflect back your request.
 - (ii) Empathize with them even if they refuse.
- After sharing your feelings/needs vulnerably, you will probably want to know how the other person thinks and feels. Be as specific as possible when requesting for feedback:
 - (i) To ask for *specific feelings*, ask "Could you tell me how you're feeling about...?" rather than "How are you feeling?"
 - (ii) To ask for *specific thoughts*, ask something like, "Do you think the proposed changes to the project will be successful? If not, what must we change to improve its chances of success?" rather than "What do you think?"

 Remember: you are making a request, not a demand. The other person has the right to say "no." Don't try to force or manipulate others into submitting, as it'll only bring resentment and frustration.

- The difference between a demand and a request is what happens if the receiving party declines:
 - (i) It's a demand if the requester starts to judge, criticize, or see it as a form of a rejection.
 - (ii) It's a genuine request if the requester shows empathy for the other person's needs and decisions.

"We talk to others or at them without knowing how to engage in a dialogue with them."

- Treat "no" as a chance to open up a dialogue and uncover the unmet needs that are stopping the other party from saying "yes."



When you request for a group meeting, let people know when your needs are met. This allows everyone to move on instead of prolonging the discussions unnecessarily.



Receiving Empathically

This is about listening actively to the other person's observations, feelings, needs, and requests, without hearing blame or criticism.



How to Receive Empathically



To practice empathy, you must listen with your entire being, not only with your head. Shed all preconceived notions, and be fully present to what the other person is communicating.

- You can't be fully present if you're evaluating the problem intellectually in your mind. This includes: offering advice ("Why don't you..."), offering comfort ("It's not your fault..."), teaching ("You can learn from..."), one-upping ("I went through something worse..."), questioning ("How did that happen?"), or sympathizing ("Poor thing...").
- No matter what they say, focus only on their observations, feelings, needs, and requests. Paraphrase or reflect back what you heard, e.g. "Are you feeling overwhelmed because you need help with your workload?" or "Are you feeling anxious because you would like more certainty about our plans?"
 - (i) This allows them to confirm or to correct your understanding, and get more deeply in touch with themselves in the process.
 - (ii) Use a tone of voice that suggests you're just trying to understand, not stating a conclusion.
- The goal is to sustain empathy until you have fully heard the other person's observations, feelings, needs and requests.

KEY QUOTES

"Empathy...calls upon us to empty our mind and listen to others with our whole being."

"Intellectual understanding blocks empathy."

"It is a poignant experience to receive concrete evidence that someone is empathically connected to us."

When the other person feels understood, he/she will probably stop talking, and you can sense a release of tension. You can confirm by asking "Is there more that you wanted to say?"



When you're in pain, it can be hard to empathize with others. You must exercise self-empathy before you can offer empathy to others.

- If you're feeling defensive or overwhelmed:
 - (i) Breathe, calm down, and ask yourself: "What am I feeling right now? What need of mine is not being met?"
 - (ii) Scream nonviolently to convey your emotional state honestly without blame or criticism. For example: "I'm feeling distressed right now and I really need some peace and quiet. Would you be willing to take a break and discuss this later when I'm more centered?"
 - (iii) Step away from the situation, take some time to soothe yourself and reflect on our feelings and needs, before returning to the conversation with a clear mind.



Empathy is a powerful tool to create deeper connections, encourage healing, foster understanding, and prevent conflict.

- When we're empathic, we show a genuine interest in others, which encourages them to open up and engage in deeper conversations.
- When people feel heard and understood, it dissolves psychological barriers (e.g. fear, resentment, or isolation) to start the process of healing.
- Empathy can defuse potential violence, since people are less likely to resort to aggressive behavior when they feel heard and understood. When we empathize with others, we also recognize our shared humanity to stop seeing people as monsters.
- Empathy helps us to see others' refusal not as a form of rejection, but a sign of unmet needs. For example, your friend doesn't want to meet for drinks because she's exhausted and needs rest, not because she dislikes your company.
- Empathy helps to breathe life into dull conversations by injecting curiosity and authenticity into our interactions.

KEY QUOTES

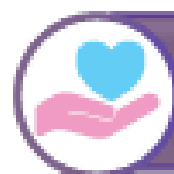
"It is impossible to give something to another if we don't have it ourselves."

"The more we empathize with the other party, the safer we feel."

"Behind intimidating messages are merely people appealing to us to meet their needs."

"All of us want our words to enrich others, not to burden them."

- It helps us to tune into unspoken feelings and needs. Try empathic questions like, "You've been quiet. Are you feeling uncomfortable and need more time to process this?"



Nurturing Relationships with Yourself and Others



Practicing Self-Compassion with NVC



NVC isn't just about connecting with others; it's also about connecting with ourselves. It's hard to empathize with others if we're harsh and critical with ourselves. Use NVC to develop self-compassion.

- Once you notice any self-criticism, pause to identify the unmet need causing the judgment and regret, so you can find better ways to fulfill that need in the future.
- Forgive yourself for the things you now regret. Realize that you were just trying to meet certain needs. Focus on learning and growing from the experience.



Engage only in activities that are aligned with your needs/values, and can enrich your life (as well as those around you).

- Don't do things out of obligation, guilt, or shame, since these will only lead to resentment and burnout.
- Stop using the words "I should" and "I have to" to avoid self-blame or a victim-mindset. Take personal responsibility by reframing your tasks with the words "I choose to."
 - (i) List down all the things you "have to" do. Reframe them with the words: "I choose to... because I want to..." For example, you can replace "I have to go to work" with "I choose to go to work because I want to support my family and contribute to something I care about."
 - (ii) Consciously align your actions with your values, needs and desires. For example, Rosenberg hated writing clinical reports—once he realized that he was doing it purely for financial reasons, he chose to focus on other more fulfilling sources of income.

KEY QUOTES

"When we are internally violent toward ourselves, it is difficult to be genuinely compassionate toward others."

"An otherwise joyful activity performed out of obligation, duty, fear, guilt, or shame will lose its joy and eventually engender resistance."

"We can replace language that implies lack of choice with language that acknowledges choice."

"In connecting moment by moment to our needs, we increase our creative capacity to act in harmony with them."



Expressing Anger and Appreciation



To fully express your anger, you must take responsibility for it. Others' actions may trigger your anger, but they are not the root cause. Your feelings are created by your own needs and perceptions.

- See anger as a sign to look inward to address unmet needs:
 - (i) Take a moment to breathe deeply.
 - (ii) Identify the judgmental thoughts fueling your anger.
 - (iii) Pinpoint the unmet needs or values causing the anger.
 - (iv) Convey those feelings and needs clearly and directly, without blame or criticism. For instance, instead of yelling "You're always late!", you could say, "I feel upset when you arrive 30 minutes after the agreed time, because I value punctuality."



Compliments can sometimes be used to judge or manipulate others. Show appreciation purely to celebrate, not to influence others or to get something in return.

- To show appreciation: Mention the specific action you're thankful for, describe the specific need that was fulfilled by the action, and the positive feeling that arose from satisfying the need. For example: "Jack, when you spent the whole day to help me move my furniture [action], I felt relieved [feeling] because I really needed help to finish the move in time [need]."
- Receive appreciation with empathy. Don't act superior nor feign humility.



Conflict Resolution



Traditional mediation vs NVC mediation. Traditional mediation aims to find a compromise between conflicting parties as quickly as possible, whereas NVC aims to build genuine connections and fulfill the needs of *all* parties.

KEY QUOTES

"At the core of all anger is a need that is not being fulfilled...To fully express anger requires full consciousness of our need."

"The cause of anger lies in our thinking—in thoughts of blame and judgment."

"Express appreciation to celebrate, not to manipulate."

"As we let our own light shine, we unconsciously give other people permission to do the same. As we are liberated from our fear, our presence automatically liberates others."

KEY QUOTES

"When we hear another person's feelings and needs, we recognize our common humanity."

"To resolve conflicts using NVC, we need to train ourselves to hear people expressing needs regardless of how they do the expressing."

- All human beings share universal needs, such as our need for autonomy, meaning, interpersonal connection, etc. However, we use different strategies to fulfill those needs. For example, we may seek social connection (a need) by meeting up with friends (a strategy). Often, conflicts are caused by clashes in strategies, not needs.
- NVC is built on the belief that all conflicts arise from unmet needs. Once those needs are understood and respected, you can find strategies that meet everyone's needs quickly.



Rosenberg presents 5 steps for NVC conflict resolution. The first 2 steps are interchangeable—either party can express their needs first.

- Express your needs clearly and specifically, focusing on what you want (not what you don't want).
- Understand their needs: Listen empathically with your whole being, even if they're being critical or judgmental. Aim to uncover the feelings and needs behind their words.
- Confirm mutual understanding, or whether you've understood each other's needs.
- If there's any confusion, sustain empathy until both sides are satisfied that their needs have been fully heard and understood.
- Once all needs are clear, brainstorm strategies to meet those needs. Present requests using positive action language, and focus on what can be done *now*.



Use NVC to resolve both internal and external conflicts:

- Free yourself from old programming and cultural conditioning, e.g. reject notions that it's weak to show sensitivity or vulnerability, or it's selfish to express your needs.
- Resolve inner conflicts to prevent depression. Recognize that all needs arise from a desire to enrich your life. Instead of judging certain desires as "bad," explore ways to satisfy *all* your needs.
- When you empathize with others' feelings and needs, it also reduces external conflict as you're less likely to judge others negatively and respond aggressively.



Use of Force



In rare situations where communication is impossible due to imminent danger, protective use of force may be necessary. For example, if a child is about to run into traffic, his parent may pull him back firmly to protect him from potential harm. The key is to protect others, not to punish or blame.

- By contrast, punitive force is about using pain or consequences to discipline or control someone. Using the same scenario, the parent might later punish the child (e.g. restrict his playtime) to teach him a lesson. Such methods are counter-productive, since they tend to create resistance and resentment. In fact, punishments and rewards don't bring true behavioral change as they don't address the needs driving the behavior.
- Before applying any force, ask yourself 2 questions:
 - (i) "What do I want this person to do?"
 - (ii) "What do I want this person's reasons to be for doing it?"

The second question will help to weed out ineffective extrinsic motivators.



Conclusion and Other Details to Look out For



NVC helps to cultivate new relationships with yourself and others, to understand and fulfill mutual needs in relationships, and achieve true peace and harmony.



The book is packed with detailed case studies and sample conversations to help readers to understand and apply the NVC principles and components. It also includes a list of universal human needs, a list of words to express feelings specifically, as well as other tips for professional mediator, therapists, and counsellors. For more details and resources, please visit <https://www.cnvc.org/>.

KEY QUOTES

"We can never make people do anything."

"When we submit to doing something solely for the purpose of avoiding punishment, our attention is distracted from the value of the action itself."

"NVC helps us create a more peaceful state of mind by encouraging us to focus on what we are truly wanting rather than on what is wrong with others or ourselves."